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Boundary spanning behaviors of expatriates

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Abstract

Expatriates provide benefits to multinational corporations (MNCs) when they enact boundary spanning roles. They do so by relaying local information and identifying opportunities that meet internal needs of MNCs. To test hypotheses based on social capital and role theories, we surveyed 232 expatriates. The findings indicated that local experience and the diversity of social networks were conducive to the boundary spanning activities of expatriates, whereas environmental uncertainty and overseas experience had little effect. By engaging in boundary spanning activities, expatriates felt less role ambiguity and gained role benefits, and were more eager to use the resources that were found within different communities of the host country. In addition, those expatriates who engaged in more boundary spanning activities had higher job satisfaction and more power within their own companies than those who did not.

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1. Boundary spanning behaviors of expatriates

Expatriates are playing an indispensable role in MNCs as globalization reaches a new level. Unlike in the 1970s and 1980s, power in many MNCs is now more geographically delegated. Company headquarters impose less control over and give more freedom to their overseas subsidiaries. This is aimed at developing strategic connections between subsidiaries in different nations, so that they can exploit the advantages of transnational acquisition and use of resources (Bartlett & Ghoshal, 1989; Nohria & Ghoshal, 1997).

Expatriates have the potential to play key roles in MNCs because they are able to act as the links through which subsidiaries can connect to the host countries to obtain useful resources (Thomas, 1994). Caligiuri (1997) found that the “success” of expatriates could be evaluated by measures that included the completion of assignments, cross-cultural adjustment, and performance. Her study showed that expatriates and their peers further divided performance into technical, pro-social, managerial, and expatriate-specific categories. The last two types of performance include repre-

senting the organizations to customers and the public, and transferring information across strategic units and establishing interpersonal bonds with host nationals—activities that many would refer to as “boundary spanning” (e.g., Ancona & Caldwell, 1992). It seems, therefore, that boundary spanning was in the mind of her respondents, even though they did not use the term.

Relatively little is known about the boundary spanning activities of expatriates. Most research that has been concerned with expatriates and their management has focused on better selection, training, adjustment, and completion of assignments (Black, Mendenhall, & Oddou, 1991; Fukuda & Chu, 1994; Inkson, Arthur, Pringle, & Barry, 1997; Thomas, 1998). In short, the majority of the literature focuses on helping expatriates to cope with their new environments and reducing the potential loss to MNCs when those expatriates fail in their assignments. Given this focus, the important question of how expatriates do their jobs during their foreign appointments has not been given adequate attention (Caligiuri, 1997).

This study is an empirical effort to explore the boundary spanning of expatriates and to shed more light on how they do their jobs. In the following analysis we use the work of Thomas (1994) as a springboard for deriving theoretical propositions that are pertinent to the antecedents of boundary spanning behavior. We also examine the influence of boundary spanning behavior on psychological and social

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mediators, and its influence on work outcomes. Theories of role and social capital are considered to enrich our conceptualization. In particular, we postulate that expatriates are multicultural brokers for different ethnic or expatriate communities in the host country. Most expatriates are connected to both their parent MNC and their host country. They possess at least some cross-cultural experience, and are assigned managerial duties. Consequently, they are well equipped to establish social ties and bring together resources that are located within separate cultural communities (Cohen, 1977; Fernandez & Barr, 1993). Viewing expatriates as multicultural brokers may complement the individual point of view that Thomas (1994) implied in his boundary spanning framework.

1.1. The concept of boundary spanning

Organizations are open systems that need to interact with and adjust to their external environments. Boundary spanning is the activity by which individuals within organizations bridge external needs and provide information for internal users (Scott, 1995). In the context of this study, boundary spanning activity is broadly defined as the amount of cross-boundary information that managers exchange. Those managers who cross the boundary between the organization and the environment are called boundary spanners. These boundary spanners, because of their multi-dimensional activities, have been called information gatekeepers, external representatives of the firm, conduits for resource acquisition, and influence agents (Aldrich & Herker, 1977; Ancona & Caldwell, 1992).

Straddling the border, a boundary spanner (in the context of this study, an expatriate), is under scrutiny and pressure from a number of agents, such as suppliers, headquarters bosses, and local coworkers. Paradoxically, the diverse demands from these agents can result in both adverse and beneficial outcomes (Sieber, 1974). Before examining why this is so, we describe some factors that trigger the boundary spanning behavior of expatriates.

1.2. Antecedents of boundary spanning behaviors of expatriates

The external environment contains elements over which organizations have little control, and for whom they pose fundamental problems. Environments differ in their degree of uncertainty, and different degrees of uncertainty require appropriate degrees of intelligence collection and information processing (Dollinger, 1984). Therefore, expatriates who perceive the environment as uncertain tend to engage in more boundary spanning activities. Moreover, people with greater experience of other functional groups are more likely to participate in boundary spanning activities (Ancona & Caldwell, 1988). As expatriates are sent on more overseas assignments, they are exposed to more cultural groups and managerial functions (Mendenhall, Kühmann, Stahl, &

Osland, 2002). Hence, expatriates who have more overseas experience are more likely to be sensitive to the need to participate in boundary spanning than are those with less experience (Thomas, 1994). Hence, more overseas experience may be associated with increased boundary spanning activities.

Hypothesis 1a: *The perception of high levels of environmental uncertainty increases the boundary spanning activities of expatriates.*

Hypothesis 1b: *Expatriates with more overseas experience participate in more boundary spanning activities.*

The networking activities of expatriates can contribute to boundary spanning. This occurs when they build and maintain links with different groups of insiders and outsiders (Krackhardt, 1994), and in the process tap into the social capital that is contained in these networks. Social capital is a feature that is constituted by certain types of relationships among people, and its possession can facilitate their actions (Coleman, 1988). According to Burt (1992: 62), social capital is "... an army of people processing information who can call your attention to key bits." Access to information is particularly relevant to boundary spanners (Baron, Field, & Schuller, 2000). Because information is costly to collect, knowing the right contacts can help individuals to acquire information. Oftentimes, the contacts can also provide the gist of the information and point to trustworthy sources (Coleman, 1988). Boundary spanners must relate to a variety of groups that serve different functions for the organization (Manev & Stevenson, 1996). They must also acquire information from outside and then pass this over to organizational members, and vice versa. Therefore, expatriates who have a diverse array of internal and external relationships are well placed to undertake boundary spanning activities. In technical terms, having a variety of contacts means that an individual's social network contains diverse relationships (Blau, Ruan, & Ardelt, 1991).

Hypothesis 2a: *Relationally diverse social networks increase the boundary spanning activities of expatriates.*

Whilst selection and training may render expatriates more multicultural than local managers, their linkages with their home countries and their parent MNCs, and their new connections with their host nations, constitute a culturally diverse network (Nohria & Ghoshal, 1997: 158). A culturally diverse network is not equivalent to a relationally diverse network. One may know many customers and local coworkers, etc., but they may all come from the same country. Similarly, one may know people from many different countries, but all of them may be customers. A culturally diverse network is conducive to boundary spanning for expatriates because different kinds of information are embedded within different cultural groups

(Cohen, 1977; Smith, 1999). For example, Yum (1988) found that immigrants in Hawaii were more able to locate crucial information when they had ethnically diverse networks. They were better able to obtain information that would otherwise have resided in isolated ethnic communities. Consequently, expatriates who had culturally diverse social networks were better able to perform boundary spanning roles for their companies than those (be they local or expatriate) who lacked these contacts.

Hypothesis 2b: *Culturally diverse social networks increase the boundary spanning activities of expatriates.*

1.3. Effects of boundary spanning activities on social psychological mediators

Role theory postulates that because of their social positions, individuals must play many roles. In enacting these roles, they are influenced by the expectations of others. They have to constantly select the appropriate roles to act and the correct sets of behavior to display according to the changing demands of the environment and the audience (Sarbin & Allen, 1968). At times, different expectations that are inherent in the role set can inflict pressure on individuals. When the internal and external agents of a company exert implicit and incomplete pressure, boundary spanners experience role ambiguity (Kahn, Wolfe, Quinn, Snoek, & Rosenthal, 1964). Expatriates experience role ambiguity because they must serve the headquarters, meet local needs, and live according to different cultural norms (Black et al., 1991; Black, Gregersen, & Mendenhall, 1992).

As expatriates play out their boundary spanning roles, their behavior is subject to the ambiguous and implicit expectations of outsiders and insiders. Those who engage in boundary spanning activities may feel even more confused about their roles (Thomas, 1994). We therefore expect boundary spanning activities to be associated with role ambiguity.

Hypothesis 3a: *Increased boundary spanning activities increase the role ambiguity of expatriates.*

While competing expectations that are brought about by playing multiple roles cause anxiety in expatriates, being involved in multiple roles can also be beneficial. As Sieber (1974) explained when introducing the concept of role accumulation, the role of a “negotiator” is stressful and confusing, but it also allows opportunity for professional visibility, career networking, and fun and excitement. Indeed, being a boundary spanner can be useful because it provides a greater chance for promotion and greater access to strategic decision making (Aldrich & Herker, 1977). The concept of role benefits denotes the psychological perquisites and career benefits that one receives (Keaveney & Nelson, 1993) when playing multiple roles. It differs from role ambiguity, although the two concepts seem to be two

sides of the same coin. It is expected that because they span boundaries, expatriates acquire tremendous role benefits: they can obtain resources, status, and information that others cannot (Thomas, 1994).

Hypothesis 3b: *Increased boundary spanning activities increase the role benefits of expatriates.*

Role ambiguity and role benefits are psychological consequences that affect expatriates as individuals. Because expatriates typically have more diverse cultural networks than local managers and are more capable of boundary spanning, they can tap into the social capital that resides in different social networks. Hence, they become culture brokers who can connect groups and resources that would otherwise be scattered (Smith, 1999; Thomas, 1994: 148). Cohen (1977) and Chikudate (1995) suggest that expatriates from particular nations tended to huddle together among themselves and connect minimally with local and other foreign nationals. The social capital that is embedded in the relations of these disconnected groups is therefore bounded. A similar pattern occurs among minorities in the U.S.A. Fernandez and Barr (1993) have argued that one of the advantages of organizational diversity is to have minority managers who are able to use their social ties with ethnic communities and help their employers to spot new business opportunities that would otherwise be unknown to main-stream companies. Similarly, expatriates may be able to bridge expatriate communities and mobilize embedded resources, such as information, trustworthiness, and norm enforcement (Coleman, 1988), for the benefit of MNCs.

Expatriates who engage in boundary spanning activities are likely to be particularly capable of knowing groups and communities with diverse cultural backgrounds, and capable of connecting with internal agents (Nohria & Ghoshal, 1997). Consequently, they can manipulate resources among these communities. In our research we used a construct that was labeled “use of community resources” to capture this ability to tap resources from diverse communities. This construct differs from social capital in that it refers to whether a person can utilize the resources that exist within the different constituents of a community, rather than to any socially gained skills or advantages.

Hypothesis 3c: *High levels of boundary spanning activity increase the use of community resources by expatriates.*

1.4. Effects on work outcomes

The effect of role stress, as measured by role ambiguity, has been shown to have a negative correlation with job satisfaction (Naumann, 1993). However, role benefits increase job satisfaction because they give expatriates good reasons to work and to stay in their jobs (Keaveney & Nelson, 1993). The use of community resources means that

expatriates are better able to gain information and opportunities from diverse sources than are local managers. Consequently, they can do their jobs better and they feel happier.

Hypothesis 4a: *Job satisfaction is reduced by role ambiguity but is increased by role benefits and the use of community resources.*

In addition to job satisfaction, we were also interested in the organizational power or influence of expatriates within their organizations (Tushman & Romanelli, 1983). The measurement of expatriate success requires multiple criteria (Black et al., 1991; Caligiuri, 1997). When effectively used, power enhances leadership, helps to promote organizational change, and facilitates hiring and firing decisions (Pfeffer, 1992). We expect that expatriates who experience role benefits and acquire community resources would exert more power than those who lack such attributes, because tying organizations to the external environment tends to confer power to the linked individuals. Indeed, the uncertainty in the environment would make local organizational members defer to expatriates, who have control of information and who are able to bring in external resources to boost their positions.

Hypothesis 4b: *The organizational power of expatriates is increased by their role benefits and their use of community resources.*

2. Method

2.1. Background

Hong Kong is a metropolis of 6.5 million people in which the East meets the West. It is also a financial center that houses the Asian-Pacific headquarters of over 900 multinational companies. According to the Immigration Department of Hong Kong, there were more than 0.5 million expatriate residents in February 1998. Most expatriates were from English speaking countries. Other expatriate communities were smaller. The number of Japanese expatriates, for example, ranked only seventh among all expatriate groups.

2.2. Preliminary field study

We first went to “happy hour” gatherings that were organized by different overseas business associations, such as the American Chamber of Commerce, to observe the dynamics of interaction among expatriates. The conversations informed us on the networking and the boundary spanning activities of expatriates. We then arranged for 30 interviews with expatriates who worked in American and Japanese financial institutions. These observations and the interviews helped to assure us that we have covered important areas in the questionnaire that we designed.

2.3. Survey

2.3.1. Subjects

A total of 745 expatriates were solicited through fax messages to participate in our study, and 425 of them (57%) agreed. We mailed the potential respondents a two-page questionnaire with a stamped, self-addressed envelope for them to fill out anonymously. After two rounds of mailing that were 1 month apart, 232 questionnaires (31%, out of 745) were returned.

Following the practice of Oddou, Derr, and Black (1995) and Tung (1988), the respondents were first categorized into three groups that were based on nationality. There were 71 Japanese expatriates, 115 expatriates from English speaking countries (58 U.S.A., 49 British expatriates, plus 18 expatriates from other English speaking countries), and 46 expatriates from continental Europe. Two dummy variables for nationality allowed for the comparison of Japanese and English speaking expatriates, and European and English speaking expatriates. The English speaking expatriates could meaningfully be categorized as a group, because regardless of their nationality their use of a common language has allowed Americans, British, Australians, and so forth to form common social networks in Hong Kong.

Similar to previous Hong Kong studies (e.g., Aryee & Stone, 1996; Black et al., 1992), we found that a majority of the expatriates were male, with all of the Japanese expatriates being male. We also discovered that compared to English speaking expatriates, the Japanese expatriates had worked in fewer countries before coming to Hong Kong, had stayed a shorter time in Hong Kong, and were more likely to be in the financial industry, married, and with a lower level of remuneration.

2.3.2. Procedure

A sampling frame was created in 1998 based on the directories of the Hong Kong Japanese Association, the American Chamber of Commerce, and the British Chamber of Commerce. Most Japanese expatriates had joined the first association while most Western expatriates belonged to one or another of the other two associations. In this sampling frame, we chose only middle and high level expatriates who belonged to service sectors, including banking and finance, retailing and wholesaling, consulting, shipping, and accounting. We expected that expatriates of the chosen ranks in these sectors were likely to have some outside contacts, and would therefore find the boundary spanning survey meaningful. Readers should nonetheless pay attention to potential problems that pertain to the generalizability of the findings.

2.3.3. Questionnaire

Expatriates responded on 5-point scales (1, strongly disagree to 5, strongly agree) that measured the constructs in the research model. *Job satisfaction* ($\alpha = 0.72$) was measured by three items that had been used in various cross-cultural studies (Leung, Smith, Wang, & Sun, 1996), namely: “I am

satisfied with my job”; “I would recommend this job to a friend”; and “this job does not measure up to my expectations”. *Individual power* ($\alpha = 0.83$) was measured by three items that were adapted from Van de Ven and Ferry (1980), namely: “I have a lot of influence in determining the work for my work unit”; “I can influence decisions concerning the operating rules, policies, and procedures of my work units”; and “I have a say in deciding the evaluation criteria of my work unit”.

Role ambiguity ($r = 0.62$) was measured by two items that were based on Beehr, Walsh, and Taber (1976), namely: “my company does not make it clear how I should do my work”; and “it is clear what is expected of me in my job”. *Role benefits* ($r = 0.38$) was measured by two items from Keaveney and Nelson (1993) that had been adapted from role research (Sieber, 1974): “my job provides me the opportunity for professional visibility”; and “my current job is a good stepping stone for my career”. The *use of community resources* was measured by two items that were developed for this study ($r = 0.31$). The first item measured whether the expatriate could tap into resources in different communities. The second item examined whether tapping into these resources was required by the job, and was divided into two aspects, namely: “my current job allows me to tap into information and resources located within groups of different cultural backgrounds in Hong Kong”; and “my job requires me to use the knowledge and personal ties of a diverse group of people”.

Boundary spanning behavior was measured by items that were derived from Ancona and Caldwell (1992). Such measurement emphasized the role perceptions of expatriates with regard to boundary spanning activities, rather than its level as emphasized in Thomas (1994). Only three roles were measured using the most robust items in their factor analysis. The fourth role in their study, that of a “guard”, was very similar to the others, and they did not include “guard” in their subsequent analysis. The “ambassador” role of being protective and persuasive in favor of the organization ($\alpha = 0.74$) was measured by four items. Expatriates were asked to indicate on a 5-point scale (1, not responsible to 5, responsible) whether they were responsible for four kinds of tasks, namely: “protecting my company from outside interference”; “preventing outsiders from ‘overloading’ my company with information or requests”; “‘talking up’ the importance of the work unit to outsiders”; and “persuading outsiders that my company performs activities that are important to the economy”.

The “task coordination” role of coordinating and negotiating with outsiders was tapped by asking about the responsibility of expatriates in three tasks ($\alpha = 0.78$), namely: “resolving business problems with people outside of my company”; “coordinating activities with people outside of my company”; and “procuring things that my company requires from outside”.

The “scout” role of scanning the environment was tapped by assessing the responsibility of expatriates in three tasks

($\alpha = 0.57$), namely: “finding out what competing firms or groups are doing”; “scanning the environment inside or outside of the organization for ideas/expertise”; and “collecting technical information/ideas from individuals outside of my company”.

As shown in our analyses (as described later), boundary spanning is multi-dimensional, as each role has different antecedents and influences. Moreover, *perceived environmental uncertainty* ($r = 0.55$) was measured by two items that were adapted from Pennings and Tripathi (1978), namely: “the environment that affects this company is uncertain”; and “the environment that affects this company is turbulent”.

The questionnaire assessed the work advice networks of respondents by using questions similar to those that were developed by Lincoln and Miller (1979). Specifically, respondents were asked to list “the people with whom you have worked closely to get your job done since you came to Hong Kong”. They could list up to 10 names. The respondents then reported the gender, age, *relationship of that person to themselves* (according to the categories of kin, coworker, professional, supplier or customer, and friend), and the *nationality* of the person (12 categories).

The above information permitted us to calculate network diversity, which refers to the variation among network members for a given attribute. An index of diversity is calculated by the formula $D = 1 - \sum p_i^2$, where p_i is the fraction of the total number of members who share the same attribute, i , and the sum is taken over all attributes (Blau et al., 1991). Suppose that there are six members in a person’s network, three of them are coworkers, two are suppliers, and one is a customer. The diversity index, D , would be calculated as follows:

$$D = 1 - \sum \{p_{20}^2 + p_{25}^2 + p_{30}^2\}$$

$$D = 1 - \sum \left\{ \left(\frac{3}{6}\right)^2 + \left(\frac{2}{6}\right)^2 + \left(\frac{1}{6}\right)^2 \right\}$$

$$= 1 - \sum \{(0.5)^2 + (0.33)^2 + (1.7)^2\} = 0.61$$

This measure has the advantage of summarizing in a single value different kinds of diversity in a person’s network. Diversity indexes have been used to study multinational teams, social identification, and minority influences (e.g., Salk & Brannen, 2000).

Demographic and job-related questions were asked in the last part of the questionnaire. Age was measured in five categories. Gender and marital status were measured by using two dummy variables. The number of countries in which the expatriate had worked before coming to Hong Kong was used as a proxy for overseas experience. Remuneration measured the total amount of compensation in seven categories, and was a proxy for the level of responsibility that the expatriate assumed. The number of years that the respondent had stayed in Hong Kong was measured as a proxy of experience in the host country. Table 1 presents the descriptive statistics and correlations of the variables.

Table 1
Descriptive statistics of variables in the models

Variable	Mean	SD	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	11	12	13	14	15	16	17	18
1. Job satisfaction	3.89	0.79	–																	
2. Organizational power	4.00	0.92	0.35***	–																
3. Ambassador role	3.48	0.93	0.14*	0.25***	–															
4. Task coordination role	3.67	0.89	0.18**	0.30***	0.51***	–														
5. Scout role	3.88	0.89	0.02	0.29***	0.40***	0.50***	–													
6. Role ambiguity	3.74	0.95	–0.41***	–0.33***	–0.24***	–0.12*	–0.11*	–												
7. Role benefit	3.71	0.87	0.49***	0.47***	0.17**	0.32***	0.18**	–0.38***	–											
8. Use of community resource	3.89	0.80	0.20***	0.08	0.38***	0.27***	0.30***	–0.15*	0.20***	–										
9. Network diversity (nationality)	0.39	0.26	0.05	0.10	0.00	0.03	0.03	0.01	0.16*	0.01	–									
10. Network diversity (relations)	0.42	0.25	0.01	0.12	0.20**	0.13*	0.12*	–0.03	0.00	0.17**	0.07	–								
11. Gender (female)	1.13	0.33	0.14*	0.12*	–0.03	0.13*	0.02	0.11*	0.09	0.03	–0.03	–0.03	–							
12. Years of Hong Kong	5.38	6.29	0.13*	0.20***	0.20***	0.23***	0.16**	–0.09	0.09	0.13*	0.02	0.05	0.05	–						
13. Age	3.09	0.93	0.12*	0.28***	0.35***	0.15*	0.18**	–0.22***	0.01	0.21***	0.00	0.08	–0.11*	0.29***	–					
14. Number of countries stayed	2.29	1.58	0.12*	0.26***	0.09	0.06	0.06	–0.19**	0.12*	0.09	0.00	0.10	–0.01	–0.04	0.31***	–				
15. Remuneration	3.47	2.16	0.20**	0.31***	0.01	–0.04	–0.01	–0.14*	0.06	–0.08	0.00	–0.12	–0.06	0.11	0.38***	0.22***	–			
16. Marriage (married)	1.78	0.42	–0.06	–0.01	0.16**	–0.02	0.11	–0.06	–0.06	0.08	–0.05	0.05	–0.33	–0.09	0.33***	0.13*	0.24***	–		
17. Nationality (Japanese)	0.31	0.46	–0.22***	–0.45***	0.11*	–0.15*	–0.09	0.04	–0.28***	0.11*	–0.08	0.05	–0.25***	–0.16**	–0.10	–0.24***	–0.41***	0.25***	–	
18. Nationality (European)	0.20	0.40	0.15*	0.16**	0.02	0.10	0.05	–0.101	0.13*	–0.02	0.06	0.00	0.01***	0.00	–0.04	0.15*	0.00	–0.04	–0.33***	–
19. Environmental uncertainty	3.37	1.08	–0.22***	0.05	0.02	–0.05	0.05	0.10	–0.17**	0.00	0.10	0.01	0.02	–0.04	0.02	–0.07	0.07	0.05	0.02	–0.06

N is between 188 and 232. All scales are 5-point.

* $p < 0.05$ (one-tailed); ** $p < 0.01$ (one-tailed); *** $p < 0.001$ (one-tailed).

Note that some of the scales are composed of only two items. Therefore, the calculation of the Cronbach alpha is not meaningful, and the correlation coefficients of the items are reported instead. Nonetheless, if calculations are carried out according to two items that are correlated at 0.3, then the value of alpha would be larger than 0.5, and items that are correlated at 0.5 would yield an alpha larger than 0.7.

Although method bias is a concern in self-reported studies, it may not be particularly strong in this instance because we took preventive action. We reversed the direction of some items in the questionnaire to reduce acquiescence bias, and used different response formats for the dependent and independent variables to mitigate response bias. Furthermore, a check after the collection of data found that the first non-rotated principal component that is based on all the measurement items accounts for only 19% of the total, and more than one third of the variables did not load on this factor (loading < 0.3). If method bias had existed, then all of the items would have shared a similar amount of systematic variance, and consequentially most of the measurement items would have been loaded on the first component (because of the common variance); and the variance that was explained by the first principal would have been relatively strong. The first principal explains far less variance and has fewer variables loaded on it than one would have expected with strong method bias (Podsakoff & Organ, 1986).

3. Results

An examination of the means indicated that most expatriates engaged in some level of boundary spanning ($M > 3$, $SD < 0.9$; 5-point scale). Regression analysis was used to test the hypotheses. The three boundary spanning variables

were regressed on perceived environmental uncertainty, the number of countries in which the expatriates had before they came to Hong Kong, two network diversity variables, and demographic control variables. As shown in Table 2, environmental uncertainty and the number of countries in which the expatriates had worked before they came to Hong Kong do not have any influence on boundary spanning activities (Hypotheses 1a and b). However, network diversity in terms of relationships is positively related to the ambassador role (Hypothesis 2a), although it is only marginally significant, $\beta = 0.14$, $p < 0.1$. This means that presenting a positive image of the company is related to a higher diversity of expatriates' relationships, such as with professionals and vendors. Network diversity in terms of nationality does not have any influence on boundary spanning activity (Hypothesis 2b). Another finding of interest is that staying longer in Hong Kong increases both ambassadorial and task coordination activities. It may be that a high level of experience of living in the host country facilitates the ability of expatriates to perform boundary spanning roles. Overall, the findings give little support to Hypotheses 1a, b, and 2b, but do give some support to Hypothesis 2a.

Role ambiguity, role benefits, and the use of community resources were studied by hierarchical regression analysis. They were regressed on control variables in step 1, and the three boundary spanning role measures were examined in step 2 (see Table 3). The boundary spanning role measures explain significantly more variance than the control variables in all three equations. The results demonstrate that the explanatory power of boundary spanning activities goes far beyond that of major demographic and social variables. In particular, the ambassador role is significantly related to role ambiguity, $\beta = -0.25$, $p < 0.05$. The negative sign means that expatriates who were responsible for presenting the company to outsiders felt less role ambiguity. Projecting the

Table 2
Regression analysis of the boundary spanning behavior of expatriates

Variable	Ambassador role	Scout role	Task coordinator role
Gender	0.07 (0.23)	−0.08 (0.22)	0.09 (0.22)
Age	0.34 (0.09)*	0.11 (0.09)	0.15 (0.09)
Years in Hong Kong	0.14 (0.01) ⁺	0.11 (0.01)	0.15 (0.01) ⁺
Marriage (married)	−0.01 (0.19)	0.04 (0.19)	0.00 (0.19)
Number of countries in which the expatriate had worked	−0.02 (0.05)	0.01 (0.05)	−0.05 (0.05)
Remuneration	0.00 (0.04)	−0.09 (0.04)	−0.18 (0.04) ⁺
Nationality (Japanese)	0.15 (0.20)	−0.10 (0.20)	−0.18 (0.20) ⁺
Nationality (European)	0.16 (0.18)*	0.03 (0.18)	0.11 (0.17)
Environmental uncertainty	−0.01 (0.06)	0.05 (0.06)	−0.02 (0.06)
Network diversity (relations)	0.14 (0.28) ⁺	0.01 (0.27)	0.08 (0.27)
Network diversity (nationality)	−0.06 (0.27)	0.01 (0.27)	−0.06 (0.26)
R^2	0.19	0.05	0.13
F	3.31*	0.75	2.00*
Adjusted R^2	0.13	−0.02	0.06

⁺ $p < 0.1$; * $p < 0.05$.

Table 3
Regression analysis of psychological and social mediators

Variable	Role ambiguity		Role benefits		Use of community resources	
Gender	0.03 (0.25)	0.05 (0.25)	0.06 (0.19)	0.04 (0.19)	0.09 (0.19)	0.09 (0.19)
Age	−0.10 (0.10)	−0.03 (0.10)	−0.22 (0.08)*	−0.30 (0.08)*	0.16 (0.08)	0.09 (0.08)
Years in Hong Kong	−0.06 (0.01)	−0.03 (0.01)	0.03 (0.01)	−0.02 (0.01)	0.13 (0.01)	0.08 (0.01)
Marriage (married)	0.05 (0.21)	0.05 (0.21)	0.12 (0.17)	0.12 (0.16)	0.01 (0.17)	0.00 (0.16)
Number of countries in which the expatriate had worked	−0.17 (0.05) ⁺	−0.17 (0.05)*	0.09 (0.04)	0.10 (0.04)	−0.01 (0.04)	−0.01 (0.04)
Remuneration	−0.16 (0.05)	−0.16 (0.05)	0.06 (0.04)	0.10 (0.04)	0.03 (0.04)	0.05 (0.04)
Nationality (Japanese)	−0.15 (0.22)	−0.10 (0.23)	−0.22 (0.18)*	−0.21 (0.17)*	0.25 (0.18)*	0.26 (0.18)*
Nationality (European)	−0.11 (0.19)	−0.07 (0.19)	0.10 (0.15)	0.06 (0.15)	0.10 (0.15)	0.07 (0.15)
Environmental uncertainty	0.04 (0.07)	0.04 (0.07)	−0.20 (0.05)*	−0.20 (0.05)*	0.01 (0.05)	0.00 (0.05)
Network diversity (relations)	−0.08 (0.30)	−0.05 (0.30)	0.14 (0.24)	0.70 (0.23)	0.17 (0.24)*	0.15 (0.23) ⁺
Network diversity (nationality)	0.02 (0.29)	−0.00 (0.29)	0.10 (0.23) ⁺	0.16 (0.22)*	−0.03 (0.23)	−0.03 (0.22)
R^2	0.10		0.19		0.12	
F	1.61		3.29*		1.94*	
Ambassador role	–	−0.25 (0.10)*	–	0.15 (0.08) ⁺	–	0.12 (0.08)
Scout role	–	0.03 (0.10)	–	0.05 (0.08)	–	0.21 (0.08)*
Task coordinator role	–	0.01 (0.11)	–	0.18 (0.08)*	–	0.03 (0.08)
R^2 change	0.04		0.08		0.08	
F	2.53 ⁺		5.41*		4.68*	
Overall R^2	0.15		0.27		0.20	
F	1.84*		3.97*		2.64*	
Adjusted R^2	0.07		0.20		0.12	

Figures are standardized coefficients. Figures in parentheses are standard errors.

⁺ $p < 0.1$; * $p < 0.05$.

company's image required that the expatriates reconciled the internal company image with outside evaluations and bridged the gap between different expectations in dealing with company members. It might be anticipated that such tasks would increase the confusion of expatriates about what was expected of them, but the results indicate the opposite. This unexpected finding is discussed below. Additionally, the results indicate that staying in a number of countries before coming to Hong Kong is negatively related to role ambiguity, $\beta = -0.17$, $p < 0.05$.

Expatriates can accrue role benefits by engaging in boundary spanning activities. Acting out the ambassador role, $\beta = 0.15$, $p < 0.1$, and the task coordinator role, $\beta = 0.18$, $p < 0.05$, are positively related to role benefits. Another interesting finding is that network diversity in terms of nationality is also positively related to role benefits, $\beta = 0.16$, $p < 0.05$, even though the boundary spanning variables are in the equation. It seems that having a culturally diverse social network not only helps expatriates with boundary spanning activities, but also gives them new career aspirations. Speculatively, a diverse social network may give expatriates more divergent perspectives concerning their career.

Three variables are negatively related to role benefits. Japanese expatriates tend to perceive a lower possibility of role benefits, $\beta = -0.21$, $p < 0.05$. This may be because the

subsidiaries of Japanese companies in Hong Kong are low status outposts for company members. Our interviews with Japanese bank managers in Hong Kong as well as some indirect evidence substantiated this view. Chikudate (1995), citing references therein, argued that group oriented practices force Japanese expatriate managers to be concerned about maintaining their positions at headquarters for some time after their overseas assignments. They probably did so because their jobs in Hong Kong were not particularly important for career development. Besides, being younger, $\beta = -0.3$, $p < 0.05$, and perceiving a more turbulent environment, $\beta = -0.2$, $p < 0.05$, working in Hong Kong also lowers Japanese expatriates' perceptions of their career prosperity.

The use of community resources is positively related to engaging in scout role activities, $\beta = 0.21$, $p < 0.05$. Performing the duty of scanning the environment helps expatriates to locate and use resources that are from different communities. Japanese expatriates use community resources to a larger extent than other expatriates, $\beta = 0.26$, $p < 0.05$. Their smaller and probably weaker community in Hong Kong may have forced them to do this. Moreover, in general, expatriates whose social network is composed of diverse relationships tend to use community resources more than those with smaller networks, $\beta = 0.15$, $p < 0.1$. As the boundary spanning variables are already in the equation,

having a diverse social network is associated with expatriates' greater use of community resources as well as with their ability to cross the boundaries of the organizations in which they work. Overall, boundary spanning behavior affects role ambiguity, role benefits, and the use of community resources. These findings support a multi-dimensional concept of boundary spanning activities, and it is clear that the three factors exert different types of influence on expatriates.

Job satisfaction and the power of the individual were also studied using hierarchical regression analysis. The three variables were first regressed on social and demographic control variables (step 1), the three mediator variables (step 2), and then on the three boundary spanning variables (step 3) to check whether they could explain additional variance (see Table 4). The three mediator variables significantly explain job satisfaction in the expected direction ($\Delta R^2 = 0.26$, $p < 0.01$). Role ambiguity, $\beta = -0.24$, $p < 0.05$, is negatively related to the job satisfaction of expatriates, whereas role benefits, $\beta = 0.33$, $p < 0.05$ and the use of community resources, $\beta = 0.13$, $p < 0.1$, are

positively related to it. The boundary spanning variables contribute little additional explanation, as the change in R^2 for step 3 is insignificant. It is also interesting to note that job satisfaction is related negatively to perceived environment uncertainty, $\beta = -0.14$, $p < 0.05$, but positively to remuneration, $\beta = 0.18$, $p < 0.05$, and being female, $\beta = 0.12$, $p < 0.1$.

The three mediator variables significantly explain individual power in the expected direction ($\Delta R^2 = 0.16$, $p < 0.01$), and so do boundary spanning roles ($\Delta R^2 = 0.03$, $p < 0.05$). The expatriates perceived themselves as possessing more power when they have a social network that is composed of diverse relationships, $\beta = 0.1$, $p < 0.1$. In addition, enacting the scout role enhanced perceptions of power, $\beta = 0.13$, $p < 0.05$. Interestingly, Japanese expatriates perceived themselves as having less power than English speaking expatriates. This may be a reflection of the relatively low status of Japanese subsidiaries in Hong Kong. In summary, the above results show that the selected psychological mediators explain the job-related variables well, which gives support to Hypotheses 4a and b.

Table 4
Regression analysis of work outcomes

Variable	Job satisfaction			Power		
Gender	0.27 (0.17)	0.13 (0.16) ⁺	0.12 (0.16) ⁺	0.20 (0.18)	0.07 (−0.18)	0.06 (−0.18)
Age	0.06 (0.07)	0.02 (−0.07)	0.03 (−0.07)	0.15 (0.07) ^{**}	0.15 (0.08) ^{**}	0.11 (−0.08)
Years in Hong Kong	0.08 (0.01)	0.20 (−0.01)	0.03 (−0.01)	0.01 (0.01)	0.07 (−0.01)	0.01 (−0.01)
Marriage (married)	−0.13 (0.16)	−0.06 (−0.14)	−0.05 (−0.14)	0.06 (0.16)	0.01 (−0.16)	−0.01 (−0.15)
Number of countries in which the expatriate had worked	−0.01 (0.04)	−0.04 (−0.04)	−0.04 (−0.04)	0.05 (0.04)	0.06 (−0.04)	0.07 (−0.04)
Remuneration	0.07 (0.03) ^{**}	0.19 (0.03) ^{**}	0.18 (0.03) ^{**}	0.04 (0.03)	0.09 (−0.03)	0.11 (−0.03)
Nationality (Japanese)	−0.04 (0.16)	0.02 (−0.15)	0.00 (−0.15)	−0.77 (0.16) ^{***}	−0.26 (0.16) ^{**}	−0.25 (0.17) ^{**}
Nationality (European)	0.27 (0.14) ⁺	0.08 (−0.13)	0.08 (−0.14)	0.05 (0.14)	−0.01 (−0.15)	0.00 (−0.15)
Environmental uncertainty	−0.17 (0.05) ^{***}	−0.15 (0.05) ^{**}	−0.14 (0.05) ^{**}	0.02 (0.05)	0.12 (0.05) ⁺	0.11 (−0.04)
R^2	0.14			0.31		
F	3.49 ^{***}			9.84 ^{***}		
Network diversity (relations)		0.01 (−0.19)	0.01 (0.19)		0.12 (0.22) ^{**}	0.10 (0.22) ⁺
Network diversity (nationality)		0.01 (−0.2)	0.02 (0.20)		0.01 (−0.21)	0.01 (−0.21)
Role ambiguity		−0.24 (0.06) ^{**}	−0.24 (0.06) ^{**}		−0.15 (0.07) ^{**}	−0.14 (0.07) ^{**}
Role benefits		0.32 (0.07) ^{**}	0.33 (0.07) ^{**}		0.34 (0.07) ^{**}	0.31 (0.08) ^{**}
Use of community resources		0.11 (−0.07)	0.13 (0.07) ⁺		−0.05 (−0.07)	−0.10 (−0.08)
R^2 change		0.24			0.14	
F		7.02 ^{**}			9.33 ^{**}	
Ambassador role			0.01 (−0.07)			0.09 (−0.08)
Scout role			−0.13 (0.07) ⁺			
Task coordinator role			0.03 (−0.07)			0.03 (−0.08)
R^2 change			0.01			0.03
F			0.98			3.10 ^{**}
Overall R^2			0.39			0.45
F			5.96 ^{**}			8.53 ^{**}
Adjusted R^2			0.33			0.42

Figures are standardized coefficients. Figures in parentheses are standard errors.

⁺ $p < 0.1$; ^{**} $p < 0.05$; ^{***} $p < 0.001$.

4. Discussion

Expatriates have difficulties in performing their jobs because they and their families must overcome adjustment problems (e.g., Fukuda & Chu, 1994). Years of research have improved our knowledge about how to handle adaptation problems (Thomas, 1998). Studies on adjustment have become so prevalent that they have forgotten why the subject was studied in the first place—because MNCs are interested in the job performance of their expatriates. In this study, we tried to ascertain how expatriates in Hong Kong worked as boundary spanners. Expatriates are important assets to MNCs, which should be better informed about what expatriates do on their overseas assignments.

The findings show that boundary spanning was practiced by many expatriates. Their activities were multi-faceted—being captured as those of task coordinator, ambassador, and scout (Ancona & Caldwell, 1992). The longer that the expatriates stayed in Hong Kong, the more that they participated in boundary spanning activities. The experience of other overseas postings, however, did not increase this participation. Perhaps, sensitivity to needs should be complemented with local experience for expatriates to engage in boundary spanning activities.

The findings also show that the social networks of expatriates were conducive to the performance of the ambassador role. Specifically, expatriates whose social networks comprised of diverse relationships, such as professionals, coworkers, and customers, were more active in presenting a positive image of their organization to outsiders. As expatriates establish links with both insiders and outsiders (Baron et al., 2000), they gain more information and are better able to relate to a variety of groups (Manev & Stevenson, 1996). Hence, they become competent in playing ambassador roles for their organizations.

Boundary spanning behavior was found to enhance the social psychological consequences of expatriates. The engagement in more ambassadorial and task coordination activities increases the role benefits for expatriates. This is in line with previous findings that psychological perquisites and career benefits come from presenting a good company image and negotiating with outsiders (Keaveney & Nelson, 1993). Moreover, being a task coordinator increased the use of community resources. Expatriates can act as culture brokers to connect groups and resources that would otherwise be scattered (Smith, 1999), and relay these resources to the internal constituents of their organization (Nohria & Ghoshal, 1997).

Furthermore, the ambassador role is negatively related to role ambiguity. This means that the presentation of a good company image reduced the role ambiguity of expatriates. This may have occurred because the goals of internal agents and those of outside agents were compatible. Keller and Holland (1975) found that when universities and contractors had common goals, university boundary spanners understood more about their roles. In this study, expatriates might be bridging parties that have common goals. For example,

both a professional group and their work organization may want to serve the society and to advance the interest of the profession. Under this circumstance, expatriates may feel no difficulty in presenting their company as important or relaying the group's requests to their company. Therefore, they would experience less but not more role ambiguity because their role actually required them to perform a coherent set of tasks. Another possible reason may explain the negative relationship with role ambiguity. The objective of engaging in boundary spanning activity is to integrate the goals of internal and external constituents. Hence, the more actively that expatriates engaged in boundary spanning, the less ambiguity that existed between internal and external pressures. Consequently, demands from different parties became similar and clear. Hence, successful boundary spanning was a way to reduce role ambiguity.

Another noteworthy finding is that having a diverse social network in terms of nationality enhances role benefits. Expatriates seemed to consider their job prospects in a better light when they had multinational ties, regardless of their boundary spanning participation. On the other hand, social networks that were composed of multiple-relationships also helped expatriates to use more community resources. As network diversity remains significant after boundary spanning variables are considered, this effect is better explained by the ability of expatriates to acquire and use information from different relationships.

Social psychological mediators explain job satisfaction and organizational power. In particular, the variance of job satisfaction was explained as well as in previous studies (e.g., Aryee & Stone, 1996; Black et al., 1991). As the assumption of boundary spanning roles enhances these mediators, boundary spanning is important for expatriates to obtain good work outcomes. The perception of less role ambiguity increased the job satisfaction and organizational power of individuals. The use of community resources also increased job satisfaction. Among the mediators, role benefits are the most important. Expatriates were more satisfied and felt more powerful when playing roles that contributed to their psychological perquisites and career benefits.

The findings concerning individual power deserve further discussion because individual power is a performance aspect that has not often been studied. Firstly, we found that Japanese expatriates perceived themselves to have less power than their European and English speaking counterparts. We are not sure whether this was because their Hong Kong subsidiaries were of less importance to Japanese MNCs (as suggested previously), or because the structure of these firms conferred their employees less power. Secondly, more diverse networks in terms of relationships gave expatriates more power. Diverse networks in terms of nationality had much weaker effects. Thirdly, the playing out of the scout role enhanced the organizational power of expatriates. Fulfilling the information needs of internal agents gives expatriates influence in any organization (Tushman & Romanelli, 1983).

However, our findings should be evaluated against a backdrop of limitations. Although the response rate is comparable to or better than that of similar studies that were conducted in Hong Kong (Aryee & Stone, 1996; Selmer, 1999) and elsewhere (Naumann, 1993), it is impossible to guarantee the representativeness of our sample. Moreover, readers should be cautioned when generalizing the findings beyond middle to high level expatriates in the service sectors. The institutional and cultural context of Hong Kong and the global objectives of MNCs in Hong Kong may restrict the validity of these findings elsewhere. In addition, because the data was obtained from a structured questionnaire, we might have missed factors that were important. For instance, future research could investigate other antecedents of boundary spanning behavior from the Thomas (1994) framework. Individual factors (such as self-monitoring), environmental factors (such as cultural distance), and structural factors (such as the formality of boundary spanning role in the MNC) might be significant.

In conclusion, this study examined an important function of expatriates—boundary spanning. The findings imply that boundary spanning activities are useful to expatriates and MNCs. Boundary spanning increases the job satisfaction and power of expatriates through reducing their role ambiguity, enhancing their role benefits, and facilitating their use of community resources. After using so many resources to help their expatriates to adapt to new environments, MNCs should waste no time in getting the best out of this group of precious human assets by taking note of the findings of this study.

The findings suggest that keeping expatriates in the same location longer and encouraging them to develop a social network of diverse relationships allow them to act as boundary spanners for MNCs. In addition, once expatriates arrive in a host country, MNCs may encourage them to network with a variety of social groups, such as their coworkers, customers, and suppliers, and people of cultural backgrounds different from themselves. According to our preliminary findings, diverse social networks facilitate expatriates to perform boundary spanning activities. Although boundary spanning behavior incurs some negative consequences, such as role ambiguity (e.g., Black et al., 1991), it provides expatriates positive consequences, such as role benefits, organizational power, and the use of community resources. The positive consequences may outweigh the negative consequences and help both the expatriates and MNCs to achieve their global and local objectives.

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